THIS WEEK'S FILE · FOUNDER FILE #008

PIETER LEVELS AND THE 40,870-LINE FILE

A self-taught Dutch developer runs a portfolio of products alone, with no investors, no employees and a way of writing software that most professionals would call reckless. One of those products, he says, makes $80,000 a month in profit from a single file. Here is how he works, and what the numbers do and don't show.

THE FILE

FOUNDER	Pieter Levels, Solo founder
COMPANY	Photo AI, Interior AI, Nomad List and Remote OK
FOUNDED	2014 onwards (a portfolio of 40 to 70 products)
HQ	Nomadic
SECTOR	AI image products and online communities
STAGE	Bootstrapped, solo
FUNDING	None (never raised venture capital)
MODEL	Subscriptions and credits across a portfolio of products

Hello again, and welcome to File #008. Thank you for staying with us.

Somewhere on a rented server there is a file called index.php. In March 2026 it was 40,870 lines long. If you printed it, you'd get a stack of paper about as thick as three or four novels.

According to the man who wrote it, that one file is the whole of a business called Photo AI. There's no team behind it and no tidy folder of well-organised code. He says it took in $105,000 that month and that $80,000 of it was profit.

Professional software engineers tend to wince when they hear this. You aren't supposed to build things this way. And yet the man who did, Pieter Levels, is probably the most famous one-person company in the world. He has been at it for more than a decade, he tells the internet what he earns as he goes, and he has never taken a cent of investment.

This week we look at how he works, what the numbers say, and which parts are worth borrowing. (All figures are in US dollars, and all of them are his own.)

THE SHORT VERSION

- **Who:** Pieter Levels, a self-taught Dutch developer known online as @levelsio.
- **What:** a portfolio of products he runs alone. Photo AI turns a few selfies into realistic photos of you. Interior AI redesigns a room from a picture. Nomad List and Remote OK are older, non-AI sites that still earn.
- **Why it matters:** he's the working proof that one person with simple tools can run several profitable products at once, and AI has made that easier for him in three different ways.
- **The number to remember:** 40,870. That was the number of lines in the single file behind Photo AI in March 2026. In July 2023 it was almost 14,000.

THE FOUNDER

In 2014 Pieter was a young Dutchman living out of a backpack in Asia with a problem he has described very plainly. He kept starting projects and not finishing them. "I was always scared to launch," he said later. He would polish something for months and then drift to the next idea.

So he made a public promise. In April 2014 he announced on his blog that he would launch 12 startups in 12 months. It was a gimmick, and he knew it. Wired wrote about him that August and pointed out, fairly, that these weren't really twelve companies. But the gimmick worked, because a deadline every month left no time for polishing.

One of the twelve was a list of cities, ranked for people who work remotely while travelling: cost of living, internet speed, weather, safety. The first version was a shared Google spreadsheet. He put it on Product Hunt, strangers started filling in the cells, and it became Nomad List. A job board for remote work, Remote OK, followed. Those two sites paid his way for years, long before AI.

He never really stopped launching things. On the Lex Fridman podcast in 2024 he was introduced as having started more than 40 companies. In a 2025 conversation with John Collison, the co-founder of Stripe, the count was "at least 70". Either way, he says the same thing every time he's asked: most ideas don't work.

Along the way he wrote a book about building products this way. He sold $50,000 of preorders before he had written it, which he puts down to having posted about 125,000 tweets over ten years. He has lived in more than 40 countries and worked from a laptop the whole time.

WHY HE WORKS ALONE

He works alone because he prefers it. "I do everything myself," he told Lex Fridman. "I'm a designer, I'm the developer, I make everything."

He has said he doesn't enjoy managing people and would rather be making things. He has also never raised venture capital, though investors have asked. His reasoning is simple.

Investor money commits you to a path where you either become enormous or you fail, and the odds of becoming enormous are a few percent. He would rather, he says, own a company that makes $10 million a year outright.

Collison's summary of the result was that these are "just Pieter Levels productions".

THE STACK

His choice of tools would get him laughed out of most software teams.

He described it on the Fridman podcast as "vanilla HTML, jQuery, PHP and SQLite". If those names mean nothing to you, the short version is that they are some of the oldest, plainest tools for building websites. Most professional developers moved on from them years ago to newer, more elaborate systems called frameworks.

Pieter didn't move on, and he's cheerful about why. Partly it was an accident: he says he never found the time to learn the newer tools. Partly it's conviction. PHP, he says, "just stays the same and works", while frameworks take "so much work to just maintain". He calls his suspicion of framework fashion "my most controversial take".

Photo AI is the extreme case. By his own post, the entire site is one PHP file, reported to run on a single rented server. He has run sites this way before. Remote OK was famously one file too.

We aren't going to tell you that's a good idea in general. For most teams it isn't. But for one person it has a real advantage, and it's the same one that runs through this whole story. Nobody else needs to understand the code, and he can hold all of it in his head. Nothing has to be explained or handed over, and no update can break it while he's on a beach.

THE AI PRODUCTS

When image-generating AI arrived in 2022, Pieter treated it the way he treats everything. He launched something small and watched whether people paid.

Interior AI came first: upload a photo of your living room and see it restyled. On the Fridman podcast he said it started at about $10,000 a month and was making "forty, fifty" thousand a month two years in.

Then came an app that made AI avatars from your selfies, which were everywhere on social media for a few weeks in late 2022. He said it made about $150,000 in a week, and "ten k a day" at the peak. Then the craze passed, as he must have known it would.

What he did next is the instructive bit. He didn't cling to the avatar app, and he didn't throw it away either. He turned it into Photo AI, a steadier product built on the same idea: train a model on your face, then produce photos of you in any setting or outfit, good enough to replace a photographer for a profile picture or a product shot. He charges a monthly subscription for it.

THE NUMBERS

Every figure here is his. None has been audited.

WHEN	PRODUCT	WHAT HE SAID
2022	The avatar app	About $150,000 in a week, “ten k a day” at the peak
July 2023	Photo AI	Almost 14,000 lines of code, $61,808 a month
2024	Interior AI	“Forty, fifty” thousand a month
September 2024	Photo AI	A record month of about $161,000. He flagged computing costs as a major expense
July 2025	The whole portfolio	About $3.1 million a year (as stated by John Collison)
March 2026	Photo AI	$105,000 revenue, $80,000 profit
September 2026	Photo AI	About $86,000 a month, on a tracker that cites him
September 2026	The whole portfolio	Business revenue “stable” at $200,000 to $250,000 a month. Revenue plus investment gains past $10 million a year (as reported by a data service)

There are three things to notice.

The numbers go down as well as up. Photo AI has gone from $161,000 in its best month to $105,000 to roughly $86,000. That isn’t a collapse, and the portfolio as a whole looks steady. But anyone who quotes you a single Pieter Levels figure without a date is leaving something out.

The margin is very high. $80,000 of profit on $105,000 of revenue is about 76 percent. He doesn’t break down the costs. The biggest is almost certainly renting the powerful computers that generate the images.

Not everything in circulation adds up. One summary of the Stripe podcast lists Remote OK at $3.4 million, which is more than the $3.1 million he’s said to earn in total. We suspect a lifetime figure got mixed up with an annual one. We’ve also seen it claimed that he wants to sell Photo AI and Interior AI. We couldn’t find him saying so. In July 2025 he said the opposite: he keeps old projects running. One of them still earns about $50 a month on code he hasn’t touched in ten years.

THREE WAYS HE USES AI

People tend to lump these together, and they’re quite different.

AI is the product. Photo AI and Interior AI are, underneath, other people’s image models with a well-made product wrapped around them. He didn’t invent the technology. What he did was package it quickly and price it sensibly.

AI helps him build. In February 2025, having never made a game, he sat down with Cursor, an AI coding tool, and about three hours later had a multiplayer flight simulator running in a web browser. It's at fly.pieter.com. Reports of what it earned range from $87,000 in its first month to more than $1 million a year, and at least one blog says the income later fell away. We'd treat all of those as unverified. He then ran a competition, Vibe Jam, for games built the same way. The first drew more than a thousand entries, and a second followed in 2026. In August 2026 he posted that he had "vibecoded" a full video editor into Photo AI, meaning he described what he wanted and let the AI write it. He's also an investor in Cursor.

AI does a job for him. Nomad List has a community of about 40,000 people, and communities need moderating. He handed that to an AI model. It reads the messages and, when someone breaks the rules, mutes them for a set time, where he would have banned them. He says it's more even-handed than he was.

And there's a fourth thing, which is less a use than a windfall. He told Collison that the share of his visitors arriving from ChatGPT had gone from about 4 percent to about 20 percent in a single month. People now ask an AI where to find remote jobs or a headshot tool, and it sends them to him.

HOW HE WORKS

From his interviews, it comes down to six habits.

1. **Launch small and fast.** Treat every idea as an experiment.
2. **Watch whether people pay.** He tells founders to get real traction, something like $50,000 to $100,000 a month, before trying to scale anything.
3. **Take payment the easy way.** Start with a simple hosted payment link. Build a proper payment system later, if ever.
4. **Keep things running.** Old projects stay on his server. They cost almost nothing and some still earn.
5. **Put the profit somewhere boring.** He recommends low-cost index funds and warns against spending everything you make.
6. **Tell people.** Everything he launches is announced to a very large audience. About 185,000 people get his posts by email alone.

WHAT MADE IT POSSIBLE

- **Ten years of audience-building** before AI arrived. When he launched Photo AI, hundreds of thousands of people already knew his name.
- **Older products that paid the bills,** so an AI experiment could fail without hurting him.
- **A stack simple enough to run alone.**
- **Speed.** He had an avatar app on sale while the craze was still going.

Readers can use the last two straight away. The first two took him a decade.

Try this

Make a public deadline. Pieter couldn't finish anything until he promised the internet a launch a month. Tell one person, or your customers, the date your next thing ships.

Start as a spreadsheet. Nomad List's first version was a shared Google Sheet. Before you build software, ask whether a sheet, a form or a document would prove the idea.

Use a payment link. If you can sell it through a hosted checkout page, don't build a payments system yet.

Give AI one small, repeating job. His was moderating a community. Yours might be sorting enquiries, tagging invoices or drafting first replies. Choose a job where a wrong answer is cheap to fix.

Keep the old things alive. Before you shut down something that still earns a little and costs almost nothing, ask what it would cost to simply leave it running.

WHAT COULD GO WRONG

Other people's models. Photo AI and Interior AI depend on image models and rented computers that he doesn't own. The big AI companies' own image tools get better every few months, and any of them could make a headshot product look unnecessary.

The file. One enormous file suits a single expert. It would be hard to hand over, hard for anyone else to check for security problems, and hard to sell. If you aren't Pieter, don't assume it will work for you.

One person. Nobody else is involved. If he's ill, bored or distracted, the business stops with him. The long tail of old projects softens that, but it's still a risk.

The audience. His distribution is his following on X. He's an outspoken presence there, on politics as well as software, and a business built on one platform and one personality is exposed to both.

His word. All of it comes from his own posts and interviews. He has been consistent for a decade, which counts for something, but nobody has audited any of it.

WHAT TO WATCH

1. **Photo AI's next dated figure.** Is it steadying at around $86,000, or still drifting down?
2. **Video.** Does the editor he added in August 2026 become a new source of income?
3. **The big labs.** How close do their free image tools get to what he charges for?
4. **A sale.** We found no sign of one. If he ever sells the AI products, that would be a real change.

The AI isn't really the unusual part of this story. Thousands of people have access to the same models. The unusual part is that he has kept the whole thing small enough to run alone for more than ten years.

That's File #008. Thank you for reading it. If it made you think of someone, forward it along, and if there's a founder you'd like to see opened next, tell us at info@aifounderfiles.com. File #009 lands next Sunday.

Where this came from: Pieter Levels' own posts and interviews, with figures as he reports them, plus press coverage and third-party trackers that we label as such. Nothing has been verified independently and we haven't spoken to him. Claude, made by Anthropic, helped research and draft this file. Spotted a mistake? Email info@aifounderfiles.com and we'll correct it.

SOURCES

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